

So you're thinking about finance

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI.

A financial advisor: **4.6** out of 10.

An entry-level analyst: **8.0**.

Same degree. Finance protects the person in the room with the client, and offers almost nothing to the person preparing the materials for that room.

The 60-second version

- The advisory and risk end holds up well. The analyst tier is among the most exposed work we score.
 - A first-year analyst's job description reads like a list of automated tasks.
 - **The timeline is the thing nobody tells you:** banking applications open up to 18 months early.
 - Everyone applies to investment banking. Far fewer apply to the roles that score better and hire more easily.
 - One honest caveat: finance is cyclical, and we can't fully separate that from AI.
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Read this bit first — it's time-sensitive

If investment banking is even slightly of interest, you need to know this now rather than in third year.

Summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months in advance. And full-time offers go primarily to people who did the internship.

Which means the decision effectively happens in your first year of university, not your third. Not the application — the *preparation*. Networking, target firms, application dates.

Plenty of capable people miss this entirely and find out when it's too late. That's the single most useful thing in this document.

What AI actually took

Financial modelling. Scenario building. Company and sector research. Earnings analysis and comparables. Deck production. Data cleaning. First-draft memos.

That isn't *adjacent* to what a first-year analyst does. It's a fairly complete description of the job.

What it can't touch: sitting with someone making the biggest financial decision of their life. Judging a risk with no historical precedent. Being the person who gets called when markets fall. Carrying regulatory responsibility for advice.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Wealth / financial advisory	4.6
Risk & compliance	5.3
Investment banking (senior)	5.7
Corporate finance / FP&A	6.8
Entry analyst / research	8.0

Exposure falls as personal accountability rises. That's the whole map, and it holds across every career we scored.

Which is awkward, because you can't start with accountability. It has to be earned — and the roles where people traditionally earned it are exactly the ones being compressed.

The bit nobody applies to

Here's something genuinely useful.

Almost everyone your age applies to investment banking. Application volumes are at records, and hiring is reportedly strongest at *associate and VP* level — meaning firms are buying experience rather than training it.

Meanwhile **wealth advisory, risk and compliance score better, hire more readily, and have far fewer applicants.**

Risk and compliance in particular is growing with regulatory expansion and struggling to fill. It's not glamorous. It's protected, and it's a real career.

Worth at least looking at, rather than defaulting to the thing everyone else wants.

The honest caveat

We'd rather tell you this than let a confident number sit there.

Finance is the most cyclical career we score. Deal activity collapsed in 2023–24 and analyst hiring collapsed with it. Both have recovered somewhat.

So some of the movement we measured is the cycle, not AI, and **we can't cleanly separate them.**

What keeps our score high is what happened to the content of the job rather than the number of seats. Major firms now interview for whether you can **direct** AI through modelling and research, rather than build the model yourself. When a profession redesigns what a first-year is for, the apprenticeship has changed regardless of how many chairs exist.

You can get the analyst seat and still not get the training the seat used to provide.

The skill nobody's teaching

Knowing when the model is wrong.

You can only spot an implausible number if you understand the business well enough — which is exactly what the old years of building models by hand used to teach you.

So the fundamentals matter *more*, not less. The difference is that nobody's going to make you learn them the slow way any more, which means you have to want to.

What we won't soften

The hours at the banking end are as bad as you've heard, and they're worst in your twenties.

It's geographically concentrated. Hiring clusters in a few financial centres. That's a life decision, not just a career one.

Competition at entry is extreme — record application volumes against selective hiring.

And people drawn primarily by the money or the prestige leave in years two and three at **high rates**. That's not a moral point. It's just that the hours only make sense if something else about the work holds you.

Does this actually sound like you?

Finance suits people who:

- Are **comfortable with consequence** — being wrong costs money belonging to someone else
- Can hold **detail and narrative at once** — the numbers and what they actually mean
- Are **genuinely commercially curious**, not just good at maths
- **Handle sustained pressure** rather than occasional pressure
- Can **build trust with people much older and wealthier** — that's the advisory core, and it's more testable than you'd think

Harder if you want predictable hours early, need geographic flexibility, or are mostly being pulled by prestige.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **Internship placement rate, and with whom.** Full-time offers flow from internships, so this is the number that matters most.
 - **When does careers support start?** If it's second year, that's already late for banking.
 - **Real quantitative depth**, compulsory rather than optional
 - **Does it place into advisory, risk and corporate finance** — or only into the oversubscribed end?
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Two things worth doing

Talk to someone in **wealth advisory or risk**, not just banking. The picture is completely different and almost nobody your age has heard it.

Then find someone two or three years into finance and ask what they actually did in year one — and whether that work still exists in the same form.

One comparison worth making

Accounting. Licensed CPA advisory scores 5.2 against entry finance at 8.0.

The pay is worse — a first-year audit associate earns \$55–70K against \$85–100K in banking. But it comes with a licence, a severe shortage, and a qualification pathway that 43 states have just made shorter and cheaper.

Different trade-off. Worth understanding rather than dismissing.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- Financial analysts — Occupational Outlook Handbook — government data on growth and pay. Read this before any recruiting-firm forecast.
 - Investment banking hiring outlook 2026 — where demand actually is. Note it's from a recruiting firm, so read it for direction rather than as neutral.
 - Are too many students choosing finance? — on the gap between where people apply and where the jobs are.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.